Remembering UMass student Eric Tarpinian-Jachym

UMass student killed while interning in Washington, D.C. this summer

By George Coulouras, Assistant News Editor

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On the night of June 30, University of Massachusetts student Eric Tarpinian-Jachym was shot four times in Washington, D.C. after being caught in a drive-by shooting between two groups. Tarpinian-Jachym was not the intended target of the shooting and had died due to his injuries the following day at the age of 21.

Tarpinian-Jachym was in Washington over the summer for an internship, serving as a Legislative Intern to the House of Representatives for Rep. Ron Estes of Kansas.

A rising senior in the Isenberg School of Management, Tarpinian-Jachym was pursuing a major in Finance and a minor in Political Science.

"It's just a tragic loss for the university community," Matthew Glennon, a senior lecturer in the Isenberg School of Management, said. Glennon met Tarpinian-Jachym while he had been his professor for Marketing 301 in the Fall 2024 semester, and Tarpinian-Jachym frequently visited Glennon's office hours.

"He was an incredibly friendly, thoughtful, a good listener with high aspirations for himself," Glennon said. "In many ways, he was like the ideal student."

Tarpinian-Jachym, a Granby native, transferred to UMass for his sophomore year from Bryant University.

Before attending college, Tarpinian-Jachym attended Pope Francis Preparatory School in Springfield. His teacher, Dan McGlathery, remembered him fondly. "We need more young people like Eric who are positive, respectful, truly intellectual and trying to develop solutions to global problems."

As his Latin teacher of three separate years, McGlathery experienced firsthand Tarpinian-Jachym's talent in the language. He received gold medal awards twice for his score on the National Latin Exam, the exam's highest honor, according to McGlathery.

"He was a superb Latin scholar, and it was a great honor and privilege to teach him at Pope Francis Prep," McGlathery said.

McGlathery also taught Tarpinian-Jachym in his Model United Nations class where he witnessed Eric's passion for politics. "He was really interested, even from high school, in politics and government, how to solve problems and handle crises. He had a great vision and was very forward thinking and futuristic."

Estes and Rep. Richard Neal, the Congressman for the town of Granby, held a bipartisan tribute for Tarpinian-Jachym in the U.S. House Chamber.

"That to me was a hopeful sign of the type of leader Eric would have been," McGlathery said. "He was someone who would want to achieve bipartisan measure at a time where there's not many people wanting to that. He wanted to reach across the aisle and solve difficult problems."

His death was also referenced by President Donald Trump in a news conference in August about crime in Washington, D.C.

According to Tarpinian-Jachym's obituary, he was a member of the Ski and Board Club, Chess Club, Finance Society and Investment Club.

On-campus, Tarpinian-Jachym was a member of the UMass Armenian Students Association. According to a statement by the association, Tarpinian-Jachym was an active member for three years and attended various social and cultural events.

"We are devastated by the loss of Eric, a bright and driven member of our community," the UMass Armenian Students Association said in a statement. "Eric's warmth, ambition and thoughtful presence left a lasting impact on those around him. He was a memorable part of the Armenian community at UMass Amherst, and he is missed dearly."

Tarpinian-Jachym had a love for fishing and was an active member of the Pioneer Valley Boat and Surf Club. Al Gagliarducci, owner of Al Gag's Custom Lures in the Springfield area, met Tarpinian-Jachym through the club.

"What a lot of people don't know about Eric is he was a top-notch outdoorsman. I mean top-notch," Gagliarducci said. "He had a great passion for fishing."

According to Gagliarducci, Tarpinian-Jachym was a very talented fisher, and "won a lot of tournaments for the club."

"He impressed the Board of Directors so much at his young age, and they said 'Hey, whenever you're ready to step in as President, you let us know'. That's how well he was respected," Gagliarducci said.

Tarpinian-Jachym had plans to become even more involved with fishing in his future, as according to Glennon, he was advising Tarpinian-Jachym on his dream of owning and operating a fishing lure business.

"He came into my office hours and said, 'Professor, I have a dream of owning my own business,'" said Glennon. "He was a very careful thinker and was trying to match his passion for fishing with owning his own business. He was moving in a very positive direction and doing things that frankly a lot of students aren't thinking about."

"Eric was just a go-getter: if somebody told him he couldn't do it, he'd get it done," Gagliarducci said.

Those who knew Tarpinian-Jachym remember the good-natured person he was, while also recognizing his potential to have accomplished much more.

"I feel the need to let people know what a wonderful young man Eric was, and what a loss it was for everyone who knew him," McGlathery said. "It's a shame that his untimely passing prevented him from being able to have more of an impact on his communities."

Two suspects involved in the shooting of Tarpinian-Jachym have been arrested and charged with first-degree murder while armed, according to The Associated Press. A third and final suspect is still wanted on the same charge.

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